APPENDIX 2

The past historic tense

The past historic tense (or *passé simple*) is used in much the same way as the *passé composé*. That is to say, it is used to indicate completed actions in the past.

However, it is important to realize that it is a narrative tense and that it can only be used in the written language: **IT IS NEVER USED IN THE SPOKEN LANGUAGE AND IT IS NEVER USED IN LETTERS TODAY.**

1. FORMATION

There are 3 different sets of endings, which must not be confused. The stem for regular verbs is found by taking the infinitive and removing the endings; irregular stems must be learnt.

ALL - er verbs	ALL -re & -ir verbs & some irregulars	Other irregulars
j' all -ai	*je fin-is*	*je reç -us*
tu all -as	*tu fin-is*	*tu reç -us*
il all -a	*il fin -it*	*il reç -ut*
nous all-âmes	*nous fin-îmes*	*nous reç-ûmes*
vous all-âtes	*vous fin-îtes*	*vous reç-ûtes*
ils all-èrent	*ils fin-irent*	*ils reç-urent*

All verbs conform to one of the above patterns except *venir* & *tenir*

je vins	**nous vînmes**	**je tins**	**nous tînmes**
tu vins	**vous vîntes**	**tu tins**	**vous tîntes**
il vint	**ils vinrent**	**il tint**	**ils tinrent**

2. COMMON IRREGULARS

a) which take the *-is* form

dormir	**je dormis**	*partir*	**je partis**
sortir	**je sortis**	*ouvrir*	**j'ouvris**
couvrir	**je couvris**	*conduire*	**je conduisis**
craindre	**je craignis**	*plaindre*	**je plaignis**
s'asseoir	**je m'assis**	*battre*	**je battis**
dire	**je dis**	*écrire*	**j'écrivis**
faire	**je fis**	*mettre*	**je mis**
mettre	**je mis**	*promettre*	**je promis**

prendre	**je pris**	*comprendre*	**je compris**
rire	**je ris**	*suivre*	**je suivis**
voir	**je vis**	*permettre*	**je permis**

b) which take the *-us* form

avoir	**j'eus**	*être*	**je fus**
recevoir	**je reçus**	*boire*	**je bus**
connaître	**je connus**	*paraître*	**je parus**
courir	**je courus**	*croire*	**je crus**
devoir	**je dus**	*il faut*	**il fallut**
lire	**je lus**	*il pleut*	**il plut**
pouvoir	**je pus**	*savoir*	**je sus**
vivre	**je vécus**	*vouloir*	**je voulus**